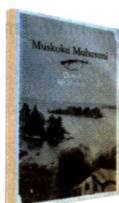


Nostalgia Track

Anglo-Indian atmospherics tied to a spy story make up this literary sandwich

By Dilip Bobb



MUSKOKA MAHARANI
by DAVID MCMAHON
Penguin
Price: Rs 275
Pages: 272

Back in the 1960s and '70s, cities like Calcutta, Bangalore, Lucknow, and the many railway colonies scattered across India were enlivened by the presence of so-called Anglo-Indians. The community, of mixed blood, British and Indian, emerged in the pre-Independence era and were specifically recruited into departments like Customs and Excise, the armed forces and the teaching profession while a large number joined the railways. By the late '80s, a majority had immigrated to countries like the UK and Australia, including the author who worked as a sports journalist with a Calcutta publica-

tion before the McMahon family moved to Melbourne. This is his second novel and it seems he cannot get the Indian out of the Anglo. His first novel was *Vegemite Vindaloo* which chronicled the life of an Anglo-Indian family's immigration to Australia. Now, we have another Anglo-Indian tale, set during the British Raj but with a contemporary twist.

David McMahon combines Anglo-Indian life in railway colonies under the British with journalism, his chosen profession, to flesh out this book but it is largely a case of nostalgia and ethnic origins winning over plot and substance. For one, the title is a bit of a misnomer. Muskoka refers to a Canadian town where an Australian journalist arrives to uncover a World War II secret, gain a sensational international scoop and save his newspaper job. The secret is held by an Anglo-Indian lady, hardly a Maharani, who was a nurse during the war, moved to London and was recruited by the British to spy on potential German collaborators. She uncovered one, who turned double agent and, released by the British under a new name, 60 years on, becomes the Pope! The spy versus spy, the sensational scoop and its denouement is pretty much treated as a side show, dismissed in a few pages. The meat of the book is about life in an Indian railway colony under the British, in the fictional town of Marsdengunj and the professional and family dramas, romances and affairs that take place around and involving the main protagonist, Serena, daughter of an engine driver with a drinking problem and a missing wife. McMahon gets the atmospherics right and he is a talented writer to boot but Marsdengunj and the multiple characters who populate and the twists and turns that govern their lives takes up too much of the book. It's almost like turning the aperitif into the main course. It's a literary sandwich that's delightfully written in parts but is derailed by excessive nostalgia. ■

TOP 10

A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

FICTION

1. 2 States: The Story of My Marriage
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
2. The Immortals of Meluha
Amish, Tara
3. Dork: The Incredible Adventures of Robin 'Einstein' Varghese
Sidin Vadukut, Penguin
4. The Lost Symbol
Dan Brown, Bantam Press
5. Way to Go
Upamanyu Chatterjee, Hamish Hamilton

NON-FICTION

1. You can Sell
Shiv Khera, Rupa
2. Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight
Rujuta Diwekar, Random House
3. Simply Fly: A Deccan Odyssey
Captain Gopinath, Collins
4. Discover the Diamond in You
Arindam Chaudhuri, Vikas
5. Stay Hungry Stay Foolish
Rashmi Bansal, CIE, IIM-Ahmedabad

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

6. May I Hebb Your Attention Pliss!
Arnab Ray, HarperCollins
7. Holmes of the Raj
Vithal Rajan, Random House
8. The White Tiger
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins

NON-FICTION

6. Nine Lives: In Search of the Sacred in Modern India
William Dalrymple, Bloomsbury
8. The Scientific Indian
APJ Abdul Kalam and Y.S. Rajan, Penguin
9. The Maruti Story
R.C. Bhargava with Seetha, Collins Business

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Teksons, Land Mark, Crossword; Mumbai: Oxford, Shah Book Stall, Modern Book Shop; Bangalore: Gangarams, Land Mark; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Land Mark

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